

RANGOON *(2017)*
Vishal Bhardwaj found his Rangoon in Arunachal Pradesh. Shot mostly in villages like **Pasighat** and **Pangin** around the Siang river, the area's dense jungles and open landscapes lent a perfect setting for this epic romance drama set in the 1940s

ROCK ON 2 *(2016)*
Shillong, called India's rock capital for its abundant talent, was a fitting location for the sequel to this musical drama about the band Magik. It was producer-actor Farhan Akhtar's attempt to bring the region into popular culture





ANEK *(2022)*
Anubhav Sinha's action drama in which Ayushmann Khurrana's police officer goes to the Northeast to broker peace between the government and the separatist groups was shot in **Assam** and **Meghalaya**. The Naga model-actress, Carol Andrea Kevichüsa, had a central part

It has also brought employment. Locals are acquainting and equipping themselves to meet the growing demand for jobs in security, catering, art production (carpenters, painters and setting boys), ground transport as well as costume design and hair and make-up, besides for junior artistes and stuntmen. So much so that the number of Mumbai-based crew on these shoots has begun dwindling, as production houses repose confidence in the skills of the local talent.

Anungla Zoe Longkumer is one such beneficiary. An author, researcher and filmmaker, Longkumer was surprised to receive a call from the makers of *Paatal Lok* to be associate researcher, translator and on-set dialogue consultant. Apart from pointing out anything controversial or inaccurate in the script which could offend local sensibilities, Longkumer suggested changes in character names and taught cast members Tillotama Shome, Nagesh Kukunoor and Jahnu Barua the state's lingua franca, Nagamese. "They gave me a lot of space and trusted me to do the work," says Longkumer about her months-long experience on shoots in both Kohima and Dimapur apart from Delhi and Kalimpong and Darjeeling. She also guided the costume and set design team on what to source so that the outfits and sets remained authentic. "So many people who come from outside have their own prejudices and perceptions about what Naga people and the place are like and what's happening here," she says. "But Sudip saw Nagaland as a place where real people face real-world issues rather than see it an unusual or foreign place, and understood that we have stories to tell of our struggles." Longkumer is excited to see how the Naga audience views the show given that the cast includes many familiar faces from among the local musicians, YouTubers and professionals from other fields. "I hope they enjoy the storytelling. This is our chance to showcase our potential."

Actress Gul Panag, who has been in the region to shoot the documentary series *Off the Road* and recently wrapped up *Family Man* Season 3, is glad that Mumbai creators are looking east. "The fact that Amazon's two big shows are set in Nagaland is a testament that inclusivity and bringing the Northeast into the fold of mainstream India is a priority for people," she says. And this is just the beginning. Handique is set to work with two leading Mumbai banners this year. He's been pitching new locations to producers on WhatsApp and netting 2-3 Hindi projects every year. The filmmakers, he says, have barely scratched the surface when it comes to locations and stories in the region. ■



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